By the time Bernier and Tavernier were criss-crossing India, Shah Jehan was no longer the emperor. The throne had been usurped in 1658 by his son Aurangzeb, who imprisoned his father in Agra fort and ruthlessly eliminated his siblings, including the liberal and scholarly Dara Shikoh. The new emperor next attempted the last great expansion of the Mughal empire. The governor of Bengal, Mir Jumla, pushed into the Brahmaputra valley in 1662 till he reached Garhgaon, between modern Jorhat and Dibrugarh, the capital of the Ahom kings of Assam. However, he was unable to completely eliminate the Ahoms due to torrential rains, the difficult terrain and constant guerrilla attacks.

Despite Aurangzeb's efforts in the north and in the east, his big push was into the southern peninsula. He shifted to the Deccan in 1682 and would never see Delhi again. Instead, he lived in a state of constant campaigning for the next twenty-six years. Although Aurangzeb extended the empire to its maximum geographical coverage, he also effectively destroyed it. His constant wars devastated the landscape and drained the exchequer. This is why Bernier comments that, although the Mughal emperor had revenues that exceeded the combined receipts of the Shah of Persia and the Ottoman Sultan, he could not be considered wealthy because it was all consumed by expenditure. Thus, Bernier tells us that Aurangzeb was 'perplexed how to pay and supply his armies'.

Equally important, Aurangzeb was a religious bigot who needlessly destroyed Hindu temples and re-imposed the hated jiziya tax on non-Muslims. It is said that when this tax was first announced, the Hindus of Delhi gathered in large numbers in front of the Red Fort to protest against it. The emperor set his elephants against them and many were trampled to death. Tegh Bahadur, the ninth Sikh guru, was executed in Delhi in 1675 for standing up for the Hindu Pandits of Kashmir. The Gurudwara Sis Gunj in Old Delhi's Chandni Chowk stands at the spot where he was beheaded.

Not surprisingly, the pact between the Hindu majority and the Mughals began to come unstuck. There were revolts in many places across the empire. One of the most successful revolts was led by the Maratha rebel Shivaji. The exploits of Shivaji and his band of Maratha guerrillas are so